



5 Easiest Vegetables to Start in an Apartment

A free guide from Seedwarden

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Open-pollinated • Community-grown • Food sovereignty for everyone

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These five vegetables were chosen for one reason: they actually work in apartments. "Easy" here means tolerant of limited light, forgiving of beginner mistakes, and productive in small containers. No grow lights required. No balcony required. Just a decent window and basic supplies.

1. Lettuce (Leaf Varieties)

Recommended variety: Black Seeded Simpson (open-pollinated, a classic since the 1850s)

- Container size: 6-8 inch wide pot, at least 4 inches deep
- Light: 4-6 hours of indirect to direct sunlight
- Days to harvest: 30-45 days (baby leaf) / 55-60 days (full head)

The one tip that matters: Cut the outer leaves first and let the center keep growing. A single pot of leaf lettuce will produce for 6-8 weeks this way instead of giving you one harvest.

Common mistake: Planting in direct, hot afternoon sun. Lettuce bolts (goes bitter and sends up a flower stalk) fast in heat. A north or east-facing window is actually ideal. If leaves start tasting bitter, move the pot to a cooler spot.

2. Green Onions / Scallions

Recommended variety: Evergreen Hardy White (open-pollinated, extremely reliable)

- Container size: Any pot at least 4 inches deep — even a repurposed yogurt container works
- Light: 4-6 hours of sunlight (very flexible)
- Days to harvest: 21-30 days from transplant / 60-70 days from seed

The one tip that matters: Buy a bunch of scallions from the grocery store. Cut off the green tops for dinner. Put the white root ends (about 2 inches) in a pot with soil, water them, and you will have new scallions in three weeks. You can do this repeatedly from the same roots.

Common mistake: Overwatering until the roots rot. The soil should be moist, not soggy. If the base of the scallion feels slimy, you are watering too much. Let the top inch of soil dry out between waterings.

3. Radishes

Recommended variety: Cherry Belle (open-pollinated, the classic round red radish)

- Container size: 6-8 inch wide pot, at least 6 inches deep
- Light: 4-6 hours of sunlight
- Days to harvest: 22-30 days (one of the fastest vegetables you can grow)

The one tip that matters: Thin the seedlings. Radishes need about 2 inches between plants to form bulbs. When sprouts are an inch tall, pull out the extras so each radish has room. The thinnings are edible — toss them in a salad.

Common mistake: Waiting too long to harvest. If you leave radishes in the soil past maturity, they turn woody and hollow. When you can see the top of the radish poking out of the soil at roughly 1 inch across, pull it. Mark your calendar from planting day.

4. Basil

Recommended variety: Genovese basil (the standard Italian variety, open-pollinated)

- Container size: 6-8 inch pot, at least 6 inches deep
- Light: 6-8 hours of direct sunlight (the most light-hungry on this list)
- Days to harvest: 50-60 days to first harvest, then ongoing

The one tip that matters: Pinch off the top set of leaves once the plant has 3 sets of true leaves. This forces the plant to branch out sideways instead of growing tall and leggy. One well-pinched basil plant produces more than three unpinched ones.

Common mistake: Letting it flower. Once basil flowers, the leaves lose flavor and the plant stops producing. The moment you see a flower bud forming at the top, pinch it off. Check every few days during warm months.

5. Cherry Tomatoes

Recommended variety: Yellow Pear or Red Cherry Large (both heirloom, open-pollinated)

- Container size: 5 gallon pot minimum (this is non-negotiable for tomatoes)
- Light: 6-8 hours of direct sunlight (a south-facing window is ideal)
- Days to harvest: 60-75 days from transplant

The one tip that matters: Choose a "determinate" or dwarf variety for indoors. These stay compact (2-3 feet) instead of sprawling to 6 feet. Tiny Tim and Red Robin are good alternatives if your window space is tight. Support the plant with a small stake or cage once it starts fruiting.

Common mistake: Inconsistent watering. Tomatoes that go from dry to soaked and back split their fruit and develop blossom end rot (dark spots on the bottom). Water when the top inch of soil is dry. Keep it steady and even. A saucer under the pot helps.

Quick Reference

Vegetable	Container	Light	Harvest
Leaf Lettuce	6-8" wide, 4" deep	4-6 hrs	30-45 days
Green Onions	Any pot, 4" deep	4-6 hrs	21-30 days
Radishes	6-8" wide, 6" deep	4-6 hrs	22-30 days
Basil	6-8" pot, 6" deep	6-8 hrs	50-60 days
Cherry Tomatoes	5 gallon pot	6-8 hrs	60-75 days

What's Next?

If this guide helped you, here are a few Seedwarden resources that go deeper:

- Apartment Seed Starting Kit (\$9) — Covers seed selection, germination schedules, and the specific setup for starting seeds indoors without grow lights. Includes printable planting calendars.
- Container Growing Blueprint Pack (\$12) — Detailed growing blueprints for 20+ vegetables in containers, including soil mix recipes, fertilizing schedules, and container size guides for every crop. Goes well beyond the basics covered here.
- 12-Month Urban Growing Planner (\$7) — A month-by-month planner for apartment growers. Tells you what to plant, what to harvest, and what to prep — so you are never guessing what comes next.

All guides focus on open-pollinated and heirloom varieties. No hybrids, no corporate seed catalogs. Just reliable, save-your-own-seed growing.

Find everything at the **Seedwarden Etsy shop**.

Disclaimer: This guide is for general educational purposes. Gardening results vary based on your specific climate, light conditions, container setup, soil quality, and care. Seedwarden provides information based on common growing practices but cannot guarantee specific outcomes. Always observe your plants and adjust based on what you see.

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